MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 4: Prose and Fiction

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

The chapter in one sentence

English prose expanded through religious translation, education, imaginative fiction, practical essays, and personal reflection.

Start with a picture

Poetry often uses lines and metre. **Prose** usually uses ordinary sentences and paragraphs, like this note. But ordinary sentence form can still carry beautiful language, complicated ideas, and imaginative stories.

Learn it step by step

1. Why prose developed

Education, printing, religious debate, travel, and interest in classical learning created more reasons to write and read English prose. Writers needed to explain beliefs, teach skills, describe unfamiliar places, and imagine different societies.

2. Thomas More: imagine another society

More’s *Utopia* describes an invented island. The imaginary society makes readers examine their own laws, wealth, punishment, and inequality. It was originally written in Latin, so it is important as an intellectual influence as well as through its later English translation.

Imagine designing a town where goods are shared. Would it reduce poverty? Would its rules restrict freedom? More encourages this sort of questioning.

3. Bible translation: language reaches more readers

Translations associated with Wycliffe, Tyndale, and Coverdale helped make scripture available in English. The Authorised or King James Version appeared in 1611. Its rhythm, parallel structures, memorable images, and familiar expressions influenced English writing.

This is not only a religious story. It is also a language story: repeated public reading can make certain rhythms and phrases widely recognisable.

4. Sidney and prose romance

Sidney’s *Arcadia* combines pastoral settings, love, adventure, and political concerns. **Pastoral** uses a rural world; **romance** brings extraordinary events and adventures. It should not be treated as a modern realistic novel.

Robert Greene also contributed to prose romance. Such narratives helped develop ways of telling longer stories, even though the later English novel would take different forms.

5. Lyly’s elaborate style

John Lyly’s *Euphues* is associated with **euphuism**: highly patterned prose using balanced phrases, contrasts, and elaborate comparisons. Think of sentences arranged as carefully as decorations on a formal cake.

6. Bacon’s compact essays

Francis Bacon often writes in **aphorisms**: short, striking statements that contain a larger argument. His essays consider conduct, relationships, learning, and ambition. They are practical and analytical rather than fictional adventures.

A made-up example of an aphoristic sentence is “A full shelf does not guarantee a thoughtful reader.” It is short, but it invites explanation. This example is not a quotation from Bacon.

7. Other important prose voices

- **Roger Ascham:** education and learning, especially *The Scholemaster*.
- **Richard Hooker:** sustained argument about religious and political order.
- **Walter Raleigh:** historical writing and accounts connected with exploration.
- **Izaak Walton:** biography and *The Compleat Angler*.
- **Thomas Browne:** reflective, learned prose, including *Religio Medici*.

Some writers discussed in this historical survey belong partly or mainly to the seventeenth century. The unit reaches beyond a strict Elizabethan boundary.

Remember these words

- **Prose:** writing in sentences and paragraphs rather than verse lines.
- **Aphorism:** a brief, memorable statement of an idea.
- **Biography:** an account of someone’s life.
- **Parallelism:** similar grammatical structures placed alongside one another.

Build an exam answer

Explain prose through its purposes: translation, education, fiction, moral reflection, and history. Match each purpose with a writer and a work. Then describe differences in style, such as Lyly’s ornament and Bacon’s compression.

Quick check

1. Was *Utopia* first written in English? **No; it was written in Latin.**
2. What is an aphorism? **A short statement carrying a substantial idea.**
3. Why did Bible translation influence literature? **It spread memorable English rhythms, vocabulary, and images.**

Develop an exam answer

Practice question

Discuss the main forces and styles involved in the development of English prose.

Expanded discussion

English prose developed because changing intellectual and social life required many kinds of writing. Religious controversy needed translation and argument; education needed explanation; travel and historical inquiry needed accounts of experience. Printing supported the circulation of these different forms. Prose therefore expanded not as a single style but as a flexible medium capable of serving practical, imaginative, and reflective purposes.

Bible translation was especially influential because it brought English language into repeated contact with worship and public listening. The rhythm, balance, and imagery of scriptural prose became part of a wider linguistic culture. More’s Utopia, originally written in Latin, contributed differently: its imaginative social comparison encouraged debate about institutions, property, and justice. Sidney’s Arcadia developed prose romance through an interaction of rural settings, adventure, love, and political concern.

Stylistic variety is equally important. Lyly’s highly patterned prose invites attention to ornament, balance, and elaborate comparison. Bacon’s essays often create a contrasting effect through compression and aphorism. Hooker’s sustained arguments and Browne’s learned reflections demonstrate further capacities of prose. A strong historical account should identify these differences instead of implying that all writers helped create the same kind of sentence. It should also recognise that the survey includes writers whose major work extends beyond Elizabeth’s reign.

Suggested answer structure

1. Reasons for prose expansion
2. Bible translation
3. More and Sidney
4. Contrast Lyly and Bacon
5. Later range and chronological qualification

Common mistakes to avoid

Do not call every long prose narrative a modern novel. Distinguish a work’s original language from its influence on English writing.

Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.

Coverage review: extra exam details

Details to develop in prose answers

The Wycliffite Bible was a late-medieval translation project associated with Wycliffe and his followers, not simply one man printing a modern edition. Tyndale's work drew on original-language scholarship and influenced later translations. Coverdale's complete English Bible appeared in 1535; the King James Version appeared in 1611. Explain their contribution through rhythm, vocabulary, parallelism, and wider scriptural engagement rather than claiming that English prose began with them.

Sidney's Arcadia combines pastoral life, romance adventure, courtly behaviour, and problems of government. The rural setting does not remove political questions. In Bacon, compact sentences often state a proposition and then qualify it through contrasts, examples, or comparisons. This is why a short essay can contain a substantial line of reasoning.

Revise further pairs: Ascham—The Scholemaster; Hooker—Of the Laws of Ecclesiastical Polity; Raleigh—The History of the World; Browne—Religio Medici; Walton—The Compleat Angler and his biographical Lives. These provide concrete evidence for otherwise very general descriptions of educational, argumentative, historical, reflective, and biographical prose.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit's assignment prompts, included as a revision checklist, not as predictions of the exam. Longer answers still need evidence from the assigned texts.

1. Write on More's Utopia as a prologue to Renaissance.
2. Explain how the translation of The Bible by various authors enlivened the English prose.
3. Trace Bacon's contribution to the development of English essays.
4. Discuss briefly the development of Mediaeval and Renaissance prose and fiction.
5. Write a note on Philip Sidney's Arcadia.